

Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Barcelona, Spain



La Delegación de Cataluña organiza la Campaña de Navidad 2016 a favor del Comedor Social "Reina de La Paz" de Barcelona - Orden Constantiniana - SACRA Y MILITAR ORDEN CONSTANTINIANA DE SAN JORGE
<https://ordenconstantiniana.org/it/la-delegacion-de-cataluna-organiza-la-campana-de-navidad-2016-a-favor-del-comedor-social-reina-de-la-paz-de-barcelona>



Aprofitem els aliments | Junts contra el malbaratament
<https://aprofitemelsaliments.org/>

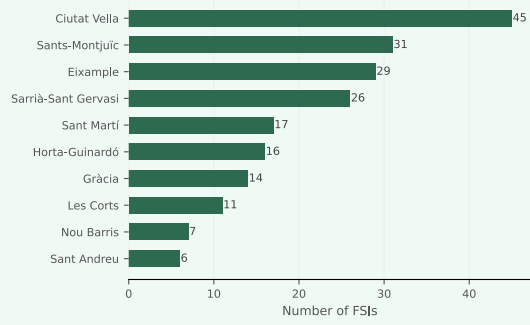


COMEDOR PARA LOS POBRES DE BARCELONA - COMUNIDAD DE SANT'EGIDIO
<https://www.santegidio.org/pageID/30820/langID/es/COMEDOR-PARA-LOS-POBRES-DE-BARCELONA.html>

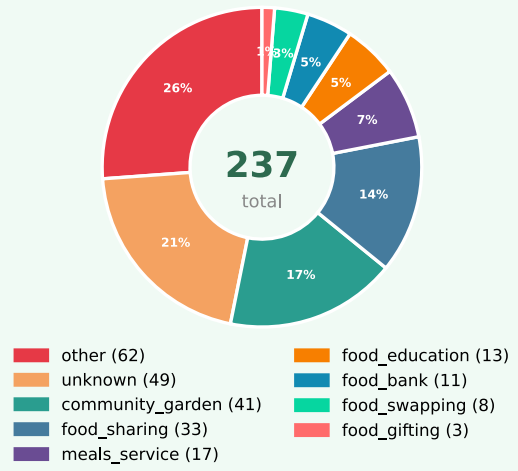


Contenedor solidario a favor de Banc d'Aliments de Barcelona
<https://tma.es/contenedor-solidario>

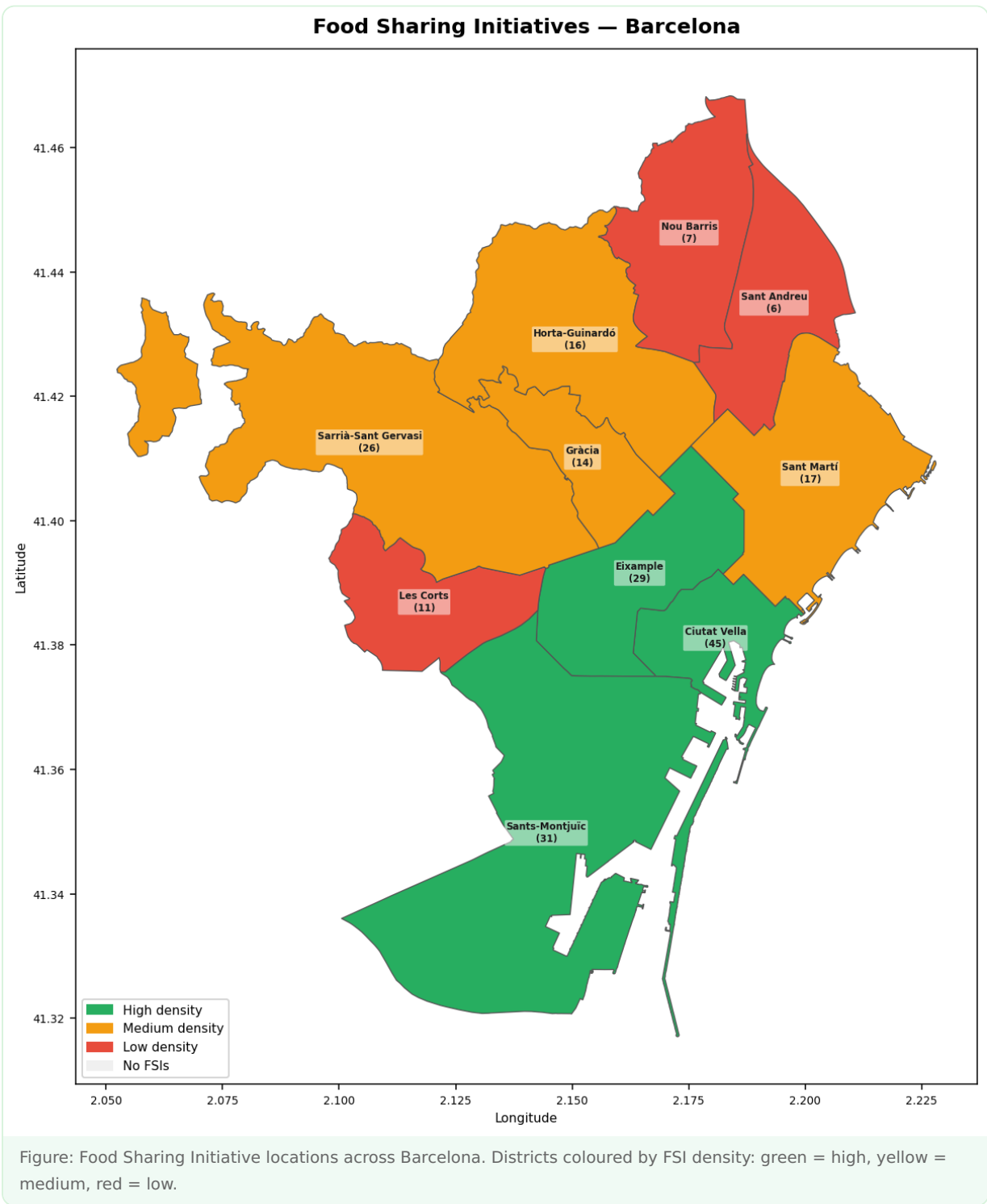
FSIS BY DISTRICT



FSI TYPE DISTRIBUTION



Geographic Distribution



Barcelona hosts 237 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) across 10 postal districts, with the highest concentrations found in Ciutat Vella (45), Sants-Montjuïc (31), and Eixample (29), which together account for 105 of the total FSIs. These three districts, designated as green (high-density) areas, collectively represent 44.3% of all FSIs in the city, reflecting a clear spatial clustering in central and historically urbanized zones. In contrast, red (low-density) districts—Les Corts, Nou Barris, and Sant Andreu—contain only 24 FSIs combined, with

Sant Andreu hosting the fewest at 6. Notably, no district has fewer than 6 FSIs, indicating a minimum threshold of activity even in the least densely populated areas.

The disparity between green and red districts is stark: green areas host 4.3 FSIs per square kilometer on average, compared to 1.2 in red districts, based on official postcode boundary polygons. Yellow (medium-density) districts, such as Sarrià-Sant Gervasi (26 FSIs) and Gràcia (14), occupy an intermediate position, with their counts aligning with their classification as transitional zones between urban cores and peripheries. Ciutat Vella's 45 FSIs, the highest in any district, suggest strong community engagement in food redistribution, potentially linked to its dense population and historical role as a commercial hub. However, the absence of per capita FSI density data limits deeper analysis of whether these numbers reflect population size or other factors. The uniformity in district-level FSI counts—none below 6—contrasts with the uneven distribution of initiatives, highlighting the influence of spatial planning and infrastructure on food sharing activity.

Types of Food Sharing Initiatives

Barcelona hosts 237 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with the largest group categorized as "other" (62, 26.2%) and "unknown" (49, 20.7%), reflecting broad or unspecified operational models. Community gardens (41, 17.3%) and food-sharing platforms (33, 13.9%) form the next most common types, indicating a focus on localized food production and redistribution. Over half of all FSIs (123, 51.9%) emphasize sustainability, suggesting a strong alignment with environmental goals, while only 12 (5.1%) integrate formal educational components, highlighting a gap between practical initiatives and structured learning opportunities. A further 105 (44.3%) organize events or workshops, underscoring active community engagement despite the limited educational scope.

The "other" category's dominance (26.2%) contrasts with the relatively small but specialized presence of food banks (11, 4.6%) and food gifting (3, 1.3%), which may reflect niche or underreported activities. Sustainability-focused FSIs outnumber those with educational components by more than tenfold, implying a prioritization of ecological impact over pedagogical goals. Meanwhile, the 105 FSIs hosting events or workshops represent 44.3% of the total, suggesting that experiential engagement is a widespread strategy, even among initiatives lacking formal education programs. This disparity highlights divergent priorities within the FSI landscape, with some groups emphasizing direct action and others focusing on long-term systemic change through sustainability. The absence of clear data on 20.7% of FSIs (labeled "unknown") also raises questions about the completeness of current classifications and potential underrepresentation of certain initiatives.

Operational and Funding Models

Barcelona hosts 237 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with the majority (227) being non-commercial, encompassing voluntary or charitable efforts. Of these, 74 are community-led grassroots projects, the largest single category, followed by 46 NGO-led initiatives and 10 commercial or social enterprises. Only 9 FSIs are government-funded, while 6 receive council support, highlighting limited public sector involvement. A small fraction (8) are

formally registered as NGOs or charities, whereas 2 operate informally through community groups, suggesting varying levels of institutional recognition and stability.

Community-led initiatives (74) outnumber NGO-led ones (46), but the latter often leverage structured networks, as only 1 FSI is affiliated with known food networks. The cooperative model is prominent, with 47 FSIs adopting this structure, potentially enhancing collective decision-making and resource sharing. Notably, just 3 FSIs are volunteer-based, while the remaining 224 rely on other staffing models, indicating limited reliance on unpaid labor. No FSIs mention crowdfunding or donations as funding sources, contrasting with the high proportion of non-commercial projects, which may depend on alternative revenue streams or in-kind contributions. This disparity underscores potential vulnerabilities in sustainability for initiatives lacking formal registration or diversified funding mechanisms.

Reach and Activity

Barcelona hosts 125 high-activity Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) and 112 low-activity FSIs, totaling 237 FSIs across the city. These initiatives collectively reference a quantified volume of 2087 units, encompassing meals, kilograms of food, or member contributions, though the exact distribution of these units remains unspecified. Notably, 30 FSIs collaborate with farms, restaurants, or stores, indicating a structured network of partnerships to redistribute surplus food. Target audiences are broadly defined, with general public (23 FSIs) and elderly individuals (36 FSIs) being the most frequently cited groups, followed by low-income populations (8 FSIs), students (2 FSIs), and children (3 FSIs).

The disparity in target audience focus highlights a prioritization of elderly and general public needs, with 36 FSIs explicitly targeting elderly individuals, compared to 23 targeting the general public. No FSIs are classified as medium-activity, a gap that contrasts with the presence of both high- and low-activity groups. Among collaborating FSIs, 30 engage with food producers or retailers, suggesting a strategic emphasis on supply-chain integration to maximize food redistribution. The absence of medium-activity FSIs may reflect either a lack of data on intermediate operational scales or a concentration of efforts in either highly active or minimally active models. Meanwhile, the relatively low number of FSIs targeting low-income groups (8) compared to elderly-focused initiatives (36) raises questions about the alignment of FSI outreach with socioeconomic needs in the city.

Digital Presence and Accessibility

Barcelona hosts 237 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), all of which maintain a digital presence as evidenced by website scraping data. Eighteen FSIs explicitly reference online or digital coordination methods in their operations, while 35 operate from physical locations, indicating a blend of virtual and in-person engagement. Notably, none of the FSIs list operating hours or frequency of activities on their websites, highlighting a significant data gap in transparency about operational schedules. The cross-lingual processing of Spanish- and Catalan-language content enabled English-language summarisation, though this does not address inconsistencies in accessibility features across FSI websites.

Among the 35 FSIs with physical locations, no data specifies their geographic distribution or capacity for community engagement, contrasting with the 18 digitally coordinated FSIs, which may rely on broader, less localized networks. The absence of operating hours or frequency details on all FSIs' websites limits understanding of their service reliability or participation opportunities. While multilingual coverage through LLM processing facilitated English summaries, the lack of standardised accessibility features—such as screen-reader compatibility or language options—may hinder inclusivity for non-English speakers or individuals with disabilities. This gap underscores the need for more structured reporting on operational details and digital accessibility, which could enhance both participation and the effectiveness of FSIs in addressing food waste and distribution challenges.

Notable Initiatives

Barcelona hosts 237 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in total, with Ciutat Vella leading in density, housing 45 FSIs—the highest concentration of any district—followed by Sants-Montjuïc (31) and Eixample (29). Of these, 125 FSIs are classified as high-popularity, indicating significant community engagement or operational scale. Notably, 105 FSIs actively organise events, suggesting a strong emphasis on social interaction and public participation, while only 12 incorporate educational components, highlighting a disparity in the types of activities prioritised across initiatives.

The contrast between event-focused FSIs (105) and those with educational elements (12) underscores differing approaches to community impact, with the former likely prioritising immediate social cohesion over long-term knowledge transfer. High-popularity FSIs (125) are distributed unevenly, with 45 in Ciutat Vella and 31 in Sants-Montjuïc, suggesting that densely populated or culturally vibrant areas may better support large-scale initiatives. Meanwhile, the relatively low number of educational FSIs (12) may reflect limited resources or focus on experiential over instructional programming, though their presence indicates a niche but intentional effort to integrate learning into food sharing. This distribution implies that FSIs in Barcelona vary significantly in scope and purpose, with event-driven models dominating in central districts.